

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Legal Operations and Compliance English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For legal operations staff, compliance managers, contract managers, policy owners, audit teams, investigation coordinators, privacy operations staff, and risk professionals.

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

approval path

The sequence of people or steps needed to authorize a decision.

attestation

A formal confirmation that a statement or requirement has been acknowledged or met.

audit

A systematic examination of evidence against defined requirements or criteria.

confidentiality

Protecting information from disclosure to people who are not authorized to receive it.

contract intake

Collecting and routing the information needed to begin contract-related work.

control

A process, approval, check, or technical safeguard designed to reduce risk.

culture

Shared patterns of behavior and expectations within a group, with variation among individuals.

data processing

Operations performed on data, such as collection, storage, transformation, or analysis.

data subject request

Request from an individual to access, correct, delete, restrict, or otherwise exercise rights over personal data.

due diligence

Structured review of facts, risks, obligations, and evidence before a transaction, onboarding, investment, or decision.

evidence

Information that supports or challenges a claim or conclusion.

exception

An item that differs from an expected rule or normal processing path.

governance

Decision structure defining roles, rights, approvals, controls, and accountability.

hotline

A designated channel for raising concerns or seeking assistance.

monitoring

Repeatedly observing information to track conditions or detect changes.

non-retaliation

Requirement that people are not punished or disadvantaged for making a good-faith report, complaint, or participation in an investigation.

personal data

Information relating to an identified or identifiable person under the relevant legal definition.

policy

Formal rule or standard that guides decisions and behavior.

process owner

The person accountable for how a defined process operates and improves.

reinforcement

Follow-up practice, reminders, or support that helps learning or behavior persist.

remediation

Work to correct a problem or reduce its effects; in environmental work, addressing contamination.

retention

Keeping customers, users, staff, or records over a stated period; specify which meaning applies.

risk acceptance

An authorized decision to retain a stated risk under specified conditions.

risk committee

A group responsible for reviewing defined risk matters and related decisions.

role-based training

Instruction tailored to the tasks and responsibilities of a particular role.

sample

A selected part of a population or material used for examination or analysis.

template

A reusable document or structure used as a starting point for consistent work.

third-party risk

Risk arising from relationships with outside providers or partners.

triage

Sorting issues by urgency, severity, risk, owner, and next action.

vendor questionnaire

A structured request for information used to evaluate a supplier's capabilities or risks.

verification

Checking whether specified requirements have been met.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Contract Intake and Workflow

A contract intake request says "urgent" but omits the agreement type, business owner, and required decision date.

Could you confirm the agreement type, business owner, and reason for the requested date? That will help the team route and prioritize the request using the actual business need.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

02 | Policy Implementation and Controls

A policy has been published, but nobody has identified who performs the related check or keeps the evidence.

Publishing the policy is one step. We also need to identify who performs the check, how often, and where its evidence is recorded so the process can operate consistently.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

03 | Compliance Audits and Evidence

An auditor requests records for a specific period. A team proposes sending a current screenshot with no date context.

Could we provide evidence covering the requested period and identify its source? A current screenshot alone may not answer the historical question in the request.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

04 | Internal Investigations

A hotline report contains an allegation and the reporter's interpretation. The intake note presents both as established facts.

I'll distinguish the reported event from the reporter's interpretation and use neutral wording. The investigation process should establish findings; the intake note should not prejudge them.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

05 | Privacy Operations and Data Requests

A data request arrives with insufficient information to identify the requester or scope. Staff are unsure which workflow applies.

Could we confirm the request type and required verification through the privacy process? Let's identify the relevant information without assuming access or disclosure is already authorized.

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

06 | Third-Party Risk and Due Diligence

Two vendors offer similar services. One handles more personal data and relies on additional subcontractors.

The service descriptions are similar, but the data handling differs. I'll make those differences visible in the due-diligence summary so the responsible team can assess the relevant risks and controls.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

07 | Training, Attestations, and Culture

Training completion is 98%, but employees still ask how to apply the policy to common situations.

Completion shows attendance or participation, not necessarily practical understanding. Let's add role-specific scenarios and check whether people can identify the appropriate action in their work.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

08 | Governance, Reporting, and Risk Committees

A risk committee tracker shows an action as complete because its plan was approved. Implementation evidence is still outstanding.

The plan is approved; implementation is not yet verified. I'll report those stages separately and identify the evidence needed before the committee treats the action as complete.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

Use the language responsibly

Fictional language practice. Legal, financial, and regulatory meanings depend on jurisdiction and context; use current documents and qualified review for actual decisions.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

US Courts: glossary of legal terms

<https://www.uscourts.gov/glossary>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.